

THE LIKELY CANDIDATES? Rajasthan CM Ashok Gehlot and Congress MP Shashi Tharoor

NANDAN DAVE

accountable, accessible leadership and organisational reforms. Two from this group—Azad and Kapil Sibal—have since quit the party. The critics point at the Gandhi siblings' interference in Punjab, where Navjot Singh Sidhu was made Congress state president despite then chief minister Captain Amarinder Singh's objection. Amarinder was later replaced by Charanjit Singh Channi, a Rahul choice. But Team Rahul calls Punjab a classic instance of how senior leaders stall change. Amarinder was asked to go, they point out, because as many as three surveys had reflected a huge anti-incumbency wave against him. But it took the 'family' nearly a year to persuade him to exit the stage, by which time the damage was irreparable. "And when the Gandhis took action, he joined hands with the BJP to sabotage the party's poll chances. The Gandhis had to take the blame," says a pro-Rahul Lok Sabha MP.

His aides say Rahul also wants to avoid the voluminous but "insignificant" paper work in the party office and concentrate on the field. "Without official duties, he can devote time to taking the Congress's message to the masses. It's not without reason that Modi and BJP target him. They fear his mass appeal," says a CWC member and Rajya Sabha MP. It would suit the BJP if the Gandhis are not at the helm, says he—and they would prefer an opponent who doesn't come with that storied family legacy. Not everyone buys this line. Many believe Rahul's helmsmanship makes it easier for the BJP to bring up dynastic politics. With him gone, they will be robbed of the plank.

CAN THERE BE A CHANGE OF HEART?

On August 28, the CWC announced the Congress presidential poll would be held on October 17. Earlier, the party had decided to complete the election process by September 20. Accordingly, on August 10, the Central Election Authority (CEA) of the Congress, headed by Madhusudan Mistry, had written to Sonia recommending that the filing of nominations begin from August 21 and wind up by August 28. This whole process has now been deferred by almost a month. This delay is not without a reason. In its lieu, the party has preponed its 'Bharat Jodo Yatra', originally scheduled to start on October 2. The march will now kick off on September 7. Beginning from Kanyakumari, it will cover 3,570 km through 12 states and end in Kashmir 160 days later. Rahul is expected to walk the whole distance, covering 25 km a day, along with a core group of 100-150 people.

AIDES SAY RAHUL WANTS TO AVOID 'INSIGNIFICANT' PAPER WORK IN THE PRESIDENT'S OFFICE AND FOCUS ON BUILDING THE PARTY

Congress leaders hope the mass outreach programme and the expected positive response to it on the ground may inspire Rahul to have a change of heart. By September 30, the new last date for nominations, Rahul will enter Karnataka, after having covered Tamil Nadu and Kerala, two states where the Congress did well in the 2019 polls. Rahul is an MP from Wayanad in Kerala. "We expect to get huge momentum and Rahul will see first-hand how common people want him to lead not just the Congress but all the forces against Modi," says a Rajya Sabha leader.

The deferment of the election will also help the party avoid a technically embarrassing situation. Rahul will flag off the yatra in the absence of Sonia, who has not been keeping well. In addition to his surname, Rahul carries a degree of legitimacy in performing that ceremonial role, having been a former party chief. If a non-Gandhi becomes president before the yatra, Rahul will have no authority to launch it, and if he still does, his opponents will have a field day, parroting old accusations against the Gandhi family.

With the family unwilling to take official charge, the Congress may have its first non-Gandhi president in 24 years. The post has been with the Gandhis since 1998, when Sonia assumed office. She remained at the helm till 2017, when Rahul took over. But even while presenting a public face of withdrawal, the Gandhi family is unlikely to give over the reins of the party to someone they cannot trust. They have been